conduct, but he didn’t plan on reciprocating any such protocol of war. Instead, he ordered his soldiers to dig a trench on one side of Panipat that effectively forced approaching riders into a tightening funnel—delivering them in a tight formation to the Mughal warriors, waiting with composite bow and arrows at the ready. They also brought a high-tech and terrifying weapon along for this particular campaign: the cannon.

Sultan Ibrahim Lodi met the Mughal army on April 21st, 1526, fully prepared for war. He brought with him 40,000 soldiers and 1,000 elephants, and stampeded directly into the prepared funnel, unaware until it was too late to pull back and attack from another direction. Babur’s forces shot the oncoming army with a crash of cannon fire, terrorizing the elephants and causing chaos for Lodi’s side. Frightened, the elephants tried to stampede away, crushing and killing many of their human companions. With backup from the long-range archers, Babur astonishingly and quite easily overcame the Sultan’s attack, killing Lodi and tens of thousands of his soldiers before the battle was over.

Delhi’s protectors dealt with, Babur moved into the city with his troops and found it just as he’d imagined: luxurious and full of unprecedented wealth. With the resources of Delhi in hand, there was nothing he couldn’t achieve in outlying India. There was money to pay for loyalty, and it was spent lavishly. Though his troops wanted to take their spoils of war and return to the cooler plains of their homelands, Babur had other ideas. He wanted to do something unusual for a man of his culture: put down roots.

To facilitate his own permanence in India, Babur continued with his army down the length of the Himalayas until he’d conquered every city from Delhi to Patna. Each independent kingdom or principality was consolidated into the burgeoning Mughal Empire as Babur and his architects physically put their mark on the cityscapes. For a civilization of fearsome conquerors, Babur’s people were incredibly adept at construction and architectural design. They loved water features, crafting waterworks so intricate that a seemingly level body of water would function practically to feed a fountain many meters away. In the lovely water gardens, crafted from stone, Babur and his advisors would hold political meetings and entertain important guests.

The Mughals were a technologically advanced civilization, not only in terms of architecture but also their metalworking. The swords used by Babur and his armies to conquer India were forged from Damascus steel, a